

Step-by-step system to get clients to pay without going to court — Action Checklist

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CONTRACT VULNERABILITIES

- ☐ **Contract Vulnerabilities:** Review your current contract template today and locate every section covering project scope definition, payment milestones, and late payment terms.
- ☐ **Contract Vulnerabilities:** Add a scope definition clause that explicitly lists deliverables and requires written change orders with agreed pricing before any additional work begins.
- ☐ **Contract Vulnerabilities:** Define payment milestones that link specific deliverables to specific payment amounts and due dates so clients cannot hide behind vague completion language.
- ☐ **Contract Vulnerabilities:** Include late fee language with both a trigger date and a consequence, such as your right to pause work when payment is 30 days overdue.

PAYMENT STRUCTURE

- ☐ **Payment Structure:** Implement a deposit requirement for all new clients, typically 30-50% of the total project cost, to reduce financial exposure from the start.
- ☐ **Payment Structure:** Break large projects into distinct phases where each phase completion triggers a specific payment amount rather than one lump sum at the end.
- ☐ **Payment Structure:** Set explicit payment due dates tied to milestone approvals, such as requiring payment within 5 business days of written client sign-off.
- ☐ **Payment Structure:** Establish your right to stop all active work immediately if a client fails to pay an overdue milestone, preventing additional unpaid labor.

DOCUMENTATION PRACTICES

- ☐ **Documentation Practices:** Create written confirmation for every scope discussion using email or project management tools that generate timestamps and records.

- ☐ **Documentation Practices:** Send formal delivery confirmations that require client acknowledgment, preventing the "I never received that" defense in future disputes.

- ☐ **Documentation Practices:** Maintain organized records of all sent invoices, payment confirmations, client responses, and delivery receipts in a dedicated folder or system.

- ☐ **Documentation Practices:** Document every client interaction about payment terms in writing rather than relying on verbal agreements that become impossible to verify later.

Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.